

THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

1995-05-19

To an individual bahá'í

1 dear bahá'í friend,

4 April 1995 concerning the character of some of the postings on bahá'í

5 subjects in electronic discussion groups, and has asked us to convey to you

6 the following.

your concerns, in the context in which you have described them in the

7 second paragraph of your message, are legitimate for a bahá'í, and you

8 should not hesitate to express them, as you wish, in a manner that is intended to
illumine the exchange of ideas in any discussion in which you

9 may participate.

The opportunity which electronic communication technology provides

10 for more speedy and thorough consultation among the friends is highly significant.
without doubt, it represents another manifestation of a devel-

11 opment eagerly anticipated by the guardian when he foresaw the creation

of "a mechanism of world intercommunication . . . embracing the whole

12 planet, freed from national hindrances and restrictions, and functioning

with marvelous swiftness and perfect regularity."

13 203-1

14 As you well appreciate, the extent to which such technology advances the

15 work of the faith depends, of course, on the manner in which it is used. As

16 a medium for bahá'ís to exchange views, it imposes on participants the same

17 requirements of moderation, candor, and courtesy as would be the case in

18 any other discussion. likewise, those involved should avoid belittling the

19 views of one another. in this regard, the house of justice has noted your

20 understandable repugnance at an apparent temptation to use misleading and
invidious labels like "traditionalists" and "liberals," which divide the bahá'í community. To
the extent that this divisive habit of mind may persist

21 in the bahá'í community, it is obviously a carryover from non-bahá'í society
22 and a manifestation of an immature conception of life. if bahá'ís were to
23 persist in this mode of thinking, it would bring to naught even the most
24 203-1. wob, p. 203.203.1

203 2

203 3

203 4

204 m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

205 worthwhile intellectual endeavor, as has so conspicuously been the case with
206 societies of the past.

207 most important of all, as with any exploration by bahá'ís of the beliefs

208 and practices of their faith, electronic discussion will serve the interests of

209 the cause and its members only as it is conducted within the framework

210 of the bahá'í Teachings and the truths they enshrine. To attempt to discuss

211 the cause of god apart from or with disdain for the authoritative guidance

212 inherent in these Teachings would clearly be a logical contradiction. To take the first
point mentioned in your letter, it is obvious that seeking to impose limits on the universality
of the authority of god's manifestation would

213 lead to the frustration of serious scholarly work and generate disharmony within an
effort whose success depends precisely upon a spirit of unity and mutual trust. The standard
is the one made clear by bahá'u'lláh himself:

The essence of belief in divine unity consisteth in regarding him

who is the manifestation of god and him who is the invisible, the

inaccessible, the unknowable essence as one and the same. by this

is meant that whatsoever pertaineth to the former, all his acts and

214 doings, whatever he ordaineth or forbiddeth, should be considered,

215 in all their aspects, and under all circumstances, and without any reservation, as
identical with the will of god himself.

216 203-2

217 with regard to the harmony of science and religion, the writings of the

central figures and the commentaries of the guardian make abundantly

218 clear that the task of humanity, including the bahá'í community that serves

219 as the “leaven” within it, is to create a global civilization which embodies both the
spiritual and material dimensions of existence. The nature and scope of such a civilization
are still beyond anything the present genera-

220 tion can conceive. The prosecution of this vast enterprise will depend on a

221 progressive interaction between the truths and principles of religion and the
discoveries and insights of scientific inquiry. This entails living with ambi-guities as a
natural and inescapable feature of the process of exploring real-

222 ity. it also requires us not to limit science to any particular school of thought

223 or methodological approach postulated in the course of its development.

224 The challenge facing bahá’í thinkers is to provide responsible leadership

225 203-2. gwb, no. 84.4.203.5

203 5a

203 6

204 1993–1996 • T h e Th r e e Ye a r Pl a n

205 5in this endeavor, since it is they who have both the priceless insights of the

206 revelation and the advantages conferred by scientific investigation.

207 The ease and relative impersonality of the electronic medium require in

208 some ways an even higher level of self-discipline than is the case in situa-tions where
a spirit of unity is reinforced by the opportunity for direct per-sonal contact and social
interaction. in the pursuit of such a spirit of unity,

209 bahá’ís will, without doubt, wish to assist the consultative processes by

210 sharing and discussing relevant bahá’í texts. This will itself have the further

211 effect of drawing attention back to the framework of b ahá’í belief.

212 The house of justice assures you of its prayers in the holy Shrines on

213 your behalf that the abundant confirmations of bahá’u’lláh may ever sustain

214 you.

215 with loving b ahá’í greetings,

Department of tHe secretariat

216 204

Emergency Contributions

to Mount Carmel Project Funds

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]